

Website Launch Checklist

FREE RESOURCE · WEB DEVELOPMENT

Website Launch Checklist

A 40-item pre-launch checklist for websites — functionality, SEO, performance, accessibility, security, and cross-browser testing — with a browser testing matrix and performance benchmarks.

40 Pre-Launch Checks

6 Categories

Browser Testing Matrix

Performance Benchmarks

40

checks

6

categories

5

browsers tested

6

benchmarks

HOW TO USE THIS CHECKLIST

Work through each category before the site goes live — not the day of launch, when there's no time left to fix what you find. Use the browser testing matrix to record actual results, and check the performance benchmarks against real tools rather than assumptions. A site that "looks right" on your own laptop can still fail several of these checks.

Functionality

8 checks

- 01 ☐ All internal links tested and working — no broken links or 404s.
- 02 ☐ All external links open correctly, with sensible new-tab behaviour where appropriate.
- 03 ☐ All forms submit successfully and field validation works as expected.
- 04 ☐ Contact and enquiry forms deliver to the correct inbox — test with a real submission.
- 05 ☐ 404 error page is styled and helpful, not a raw server error.
- 06 ☐ Search functionality (if present) returns accurate, relevant results.
- 07 ☐ All interactive elements — dropdowns, modals, sliders — work as intended.
- 08 ☐ Favicon displays correctly across browsers, tabs, and bookmarks.

SEO

7 checks

- 09 ☐ Every page has a unique, descriptive title tag.
- 10 ☐ Every page has a unique meta description.
- 11 ☐ XML sitemap generated and submitted to Google Search Console.
- 12 ☐ robots.txt configured correctly — confirm it isn't accidentally blocking the whole site.
- 13 ☐ Canonical tags set correctly to avoid duplicate content issues.
- 14 ☐ Heading structure (H1–H6) is logical, with no skipped or duplicated levels.
- 15 ☐ Image alt text is present and descriptive across the site.

Performance

7 checks

- 16 ☐ Page load time tested and optimised — target under 3 seconds.
- 17 ☐ Images compressed and served in modern formats (WebP where possible).
- 18 ☐ Core Web Vitals checked — LCP, INP, and CLS — via PageSpeed Insights.
- 19 ☐ Caching configured for static assets (images, CSS, JavaScript).
- 20 ☐ Unused CSS and JavaScript removed or minified.
- 21 ☐ CDN configured for global content delivery, if applicable.
- 22 ☐ Lazy loading implemented for below-the-fold images.

Accessibility

6 checks

- 23 ☐ Colour contrast meets WCAG AA standards for text and backgrounds.
- 24 ☐ All images have meaningful alt text, or empty alt for purely decorative images.
- 25 ☐ Site is fully navigable using the keyboard alone, with no mouse.
- 26 ☐ Form fields have associated labels — not placeholder text used as the only label.
- 27 ☐ Heading structure supports screen reader navigation.
- 28 ☐ Focus states are clearly visible for all interactive elements.

Security

7 checks

- 29 ☐ SSL certificate installed and HTTPS enforced site-wide.

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- 30 ☐ All software, plugins, and dependencies updated to their latest stable versions.
 - 31 ☐ Admin login pages protected against brute-force login attempts.
 - 32 ☐ Regular automated backups configured and tested with an actual restore.
 - 33 ☐ Sensitive data — API keys, credentials — not exposed anywhere in front-end code.
 - 34 ☐ Security headers configured (Content-Security-Policy, X-Frame-Options, and similar).
 - 35 ☐ Privacy policy and cookie consent mechanisms in place where legally required.
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Cross-Browser & Device Testing

5 checks

- 36 ☐ Site tested on Chrome, Firefox, Safari, and Edge.
 - 37 ☐ Site tested on real iOS and Android mobile devices, not only emulators.
 - 38 ☐ Responsive breakpoints checked on tablet and mobile viewport widths.
 - 39 ☐ Print stylesheet checked, if any pages are likely to be printed.
 - 40 ☐ Site tested with browser zoom at 200% to confirm text remains readable.
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Browser Testing Matrix

Record what you actually tested — not what you assume works. Include real device testing wherever possible, not only browser emulation.

Browser	Desktop Version Tested	Mobile Version Tested	Pass / Fail	Notes
Chrome				
Firefox				
Safari				
Edge				
Samsung Internet				

Performance Benchmarks

These targets reflect commonly used thresholds for good user experience and search ranking. Test the live (or staging) site, not a local development copy — real-world network conditions matter.

Metric	Target	Tool to Measure
Largest Contentful Paint (LCP)	Under 2.5 seconds	Google PageSpeed Insights / Lighthouse
Interaction to Next Paint (INP)	Under 200 milliseconds	Google PageSpeed Insights
Cumulative Layout Shift (CLS)	Under 0.1	Google PageSpeed Insights
Time to First Byte (TTFB)	Under 600 milliseconds	Chrome DevTools — Network tab
Total Page Weight (Homepage)	Under 2MB	GTmetrix / WebPageTest
Overall Performance Score	90 or above	Google PageSpeed Insights / Lighthouse

ONE FINAL CHECK

Before announcing the launch, load the site from a completely fresh browser session — no cached files, no logged-in state, no browser extensions — to see exactly what a new visitor will see.